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Part 0: General guidelines for the application of ISO 45001

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Summary of pages

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Foreword

Publishing information

This part of BS 45002 is published by BSI Standards Limited, under licence from The British Standards Institution, and came into effect on 31 March 2018. It was prepared by Technical Committee HS/1, *Occupational health and safety management*. A list of organizations represented on these committees can be obtained on request to their secretary.

Supersession

This British Standard, including its constituent parts, replaces BS OHSAS 18002:2008 and BS 18004:2008, which are withdrawn.

Use of this document

As a guide, this part of BS 45002 takes the form of guidance and recommendations. It should not be quoted as if it were a specification or a code of practice and claims of compliance cannot be made to it.

Presentational conventions

The guidance in this standard is presented in roman (i.e. upright) type. Any recommendations are expressed in sentences in which the principal auxiliary verb is “should”.

Commentary, explanation and general informative material is presented in smaller italic type, and does not constitute a normative element.

Where words have alternative spellings, the preferred spelling of the Shorter Oxford English Dictionary is used (e.g. “organization” rather than “organisation”).

Websites referred to in this standard were last viewed on 1 February 2018.

Contractual and legal considerations

This publication does not purport to include all the necessary provisions of a contract. Users are responsible for its correct application.

Compliance with a British Standard cannot confer immunity from legal obligations.

Introduction

An occupational health and safety (OH&S) management system can help an organization manage health and safety in the workplace for workers and other people affected by the organization's activities.

Organizations wishing to implement an OH&S management system for the first time, or generally improve OH&S performance, can use this document without direct reference to ISO 45001.

Organizations that wish to claim compliance with the requirements in ISO 45001 need to refer directly to ISO 45001 when using this document.

This British Standard provides a framework to help organizations successfully implement an OH&S management system based on ISO 45001, in a way that is proportionate to the organization's specific health and safety risks. For example, organizations with less complex and/or less hazardous operations often have a good idea of their main workplace risks whether there is an existing management system in place or not. ISO 45001 and this guidance provide a framework for managing OH&S risks in a more structured way and for identifying any gaps that need to be addressed.

ISO 45001, like other ISO management system standards, is based on the Plan – Do – Check – Act (PDCA) cycle and uses risk-based thinking as a method of identifying risks and opportunities in all parts of the cycle to improve performance and minimize negative outcomes.

The guidance needs to be followed in a way that reflects the hazards identified and their related OH&S risks, without adding unnecessary levels of complexity or cost. Similarly, this guidance recommends that organizations only create or store documented information if it is necessary for the effective establishment, implementation and maintenance of the OH&S management system, or required by law. When considering the supply chain, organizations need to note that smaller and/or less complex organizations can have less extensive documented information and still meet relevant requirements.

NOTE 1 For further guidance, see and the Health and Safety Executive (HSE) guidance, Health and Safety Made Simple (<http://www.hse.gov.uk/simple-health-safety/>).

NOTE 2 Under UK law, organizations cannot delegate legal responsibility for the day-to-day control of their OH&S risks even if third-party expertise, advice or services are used.

1 Scope

This British Standard describes the intent of individual clauses in ISO 45001 and provides guidance to help organizations implement an OH&S management system based on ISO 45001.

NOTE This British Standard does not add to, subtract from, or in any way modify the requirements of ISO 45001, nor does it prescribe mandatory approaches to implementation.

2 Normative references

There are no normative references in this document.

NOTE Organizations can use this document without direct reference to ISO 45001, however, organizations that wish to claim conformity to ISO 45001 should refer directly to ISO 45001 when using this document.

3 Terms and definitions

For the purposes of this document, the terms and definitions given in ISO 45001 apply.

NOTE 1 There are a number of terms defined in ISO 45001, including commonly used terms. However, when using ISO 45001 it is important to take note of these technical definitions to ensure there is no misunderstanding in its application. For example, small businesses do not always realize that the term “organization” refers to small businesses as well as larger companies (or public bodies, charities, etc.). Organization can also be used to describe one part of a business, e.g. one department or one site – if that is the extent of the OH&S management system. Similarly, the term “top management” refers to whoever directs or controls the organization – the top level decision-maker(s). In practical terms, top management can mean a small business owner, the executive board or, in a non-hierarchical structure, everyone involved in taking high level decisions.

The definition of “worker” is also worth noting. In ISO 45001 worker is all-inclusive and refers to everyone working under the control of the organization, including business owners, executive boards, senior managers, interns, volunteers, all employees and contractors.

The dictionary definition for participation relates to the action of taking part in something, whilst in the application of ISO 45001 it means specific involvement in decision-making, e.g. jointly undertaking a risk assessment and agreeing actions, being involved in deciding the organization’s OH&S policy and objectives.

NOTE 2 All of the terms and definitions within ISO 45001 can be found on the ISO Online Browsing Platform: <http://iso.org/obp>.

4 Context of the organization

COMMENTARY ON CLAUSE 4

This clause provides guidance on understanding what an organization is and does, and what can affect an organization’s ability to manage its OH&S responsibilities and achieve its intended outcomes.

This includes identifying interested parties, together with their needs and expectations, which assists in determining the scope of the organization’s management system and putting in place the processes needed to support it.

4.1 Understanding the organization and its context

How issues relating to context are determined depends on the size and/or complexity of the organization, e.g. a multi-national organization can have different sites, departments and activities, and therefore, the processes used to identify issues should reflect this complexity. A one-person business is likely to be less complex and as such, assessing issues relating to context can be simpler.

The nature of the organization is as important as its size, e.g. a five-person chemical manufacturer can have complex issues and use multiple processes to determine them, whilst a large factory producing a single product might find it appropriate to discuss context in a routine meeting.

The organization should identify all relevant issues (i.e. any that can affect the OH&S management system and its intended outcomes) and then determine those that require further attention (see [6.1](#)).

“External” issues can include, but are not limited to:

- a) relationships with external providers such as contractors or suppliers;
- b) new technologies;
- c) key drivers or perceptions relevant to the organization’s industry or sector, e.g. a move from high street retailing towards more online business can affect OH&S issues);
- d) cultural, social and political factors;
- e) relevant legislation;

- f) location of operation(s); and
- g) changes to any of the above.

“Internal” issues can include, but are not limited to:

- 1) the size, nature and activities (e.g. what it does or makes) of the organization;
- 2) the way the organization is managed and its business objectives;
- 3) resources, knowledge and competence (e.g. financial capital, numbers and capabilities of workers, technologies);
- 4) planned or foreseeable changes and how these are managed.

NOTE These lists are not exhaustive, nor do all of the issues given as examples necessarily apply to every organization.

Depending on the size and/or complexity of operations, a simple approach such as asking “what if” questions can be useful; alternatively, structured methods such as SWOT (Strengths, Weaknesses, Opportunities and Threats) or PESTLE (Political, Economic, Social, Technological, Legal, Environmental) analysis can be used.

ISO 45001 does not require a formal process or that documented information (e.g. a written or electronic record of what was done or what the conclusions are) is created to prove that issues relevant to the OH&S management system have been determined, although this can be useful. It is up to each organization to decide what suits their needs.

4.2 Understanding the needs and expectations of workers and other interested parties

An organization should identify interested parties who can affect or could be affected by the OH&S management system. These are the “relevant” interested parties.

Interested parties can include, but are not limited to:

- a) workers at any level;
- b) customers;
- c) legal and regulatory authorities;
- d) parent organizations;
- e) external providers, including suppliers, contractors and subcontractors;
- f) workers’ organizations (e.g. trade unions) and employers’ organizations;
- g) owners, shareholders, clients, visitors;
- h) insurers;
- i) the local community;
- j) the general public; and
- k) the media.

The organization should take the time to understand its relevant interested parties’ needs and expectations, determining the ones that are relevant to the OH&S management system and should be addressed.

In some instances, the needs and expectations of different interested parties can overlap with each other and with those of the organization and these can therefore be considered together, e.g. both the media and local community can be concerned about the safety around a construction site – it is the issue that is important, not the various interested parties.

4.3 Determining the scope of the OH&S management system

Once the organization has determined its external and internal issues (see [4.1](#)) and understands the needs of relevant interested parties (see [4.2](#)) it should consider what the OH&S management system is to cover, e.g. an organization can choose to cover everything it does on all sites or limit it to a single physical location.

The scope of the management system should include all of the activities under the organization's control (or influence) that can impact the OH&S performance.

EXAMPLE

Control

If a shop implements an OH&S management system it should ensure that deliveries and operations in the stockroom are covered, as well as activities on the shop floor.

Influence

Before sending workers to operate at an external site, an organization should engage with the site operators to ensure that information is shared on:

- a) health and safety risks associated with that site that can affect the organization's workers; and
- b) precautions necessary to ensure work can be carried out safely and without risk to health.

Once the scope is defined, the concept of "organization" in ISO 45001 and in this British Standard is limited to what the scope covers, e.g. if the scope of the OH&S management system is limited to a particular team or department, the rest of the organization is now considered an external provider or other interested party.

The scope should be kept as documented information, in a format relevant to the organization, e.g. an electronic or paper document, audio or video recording or a visual representation.

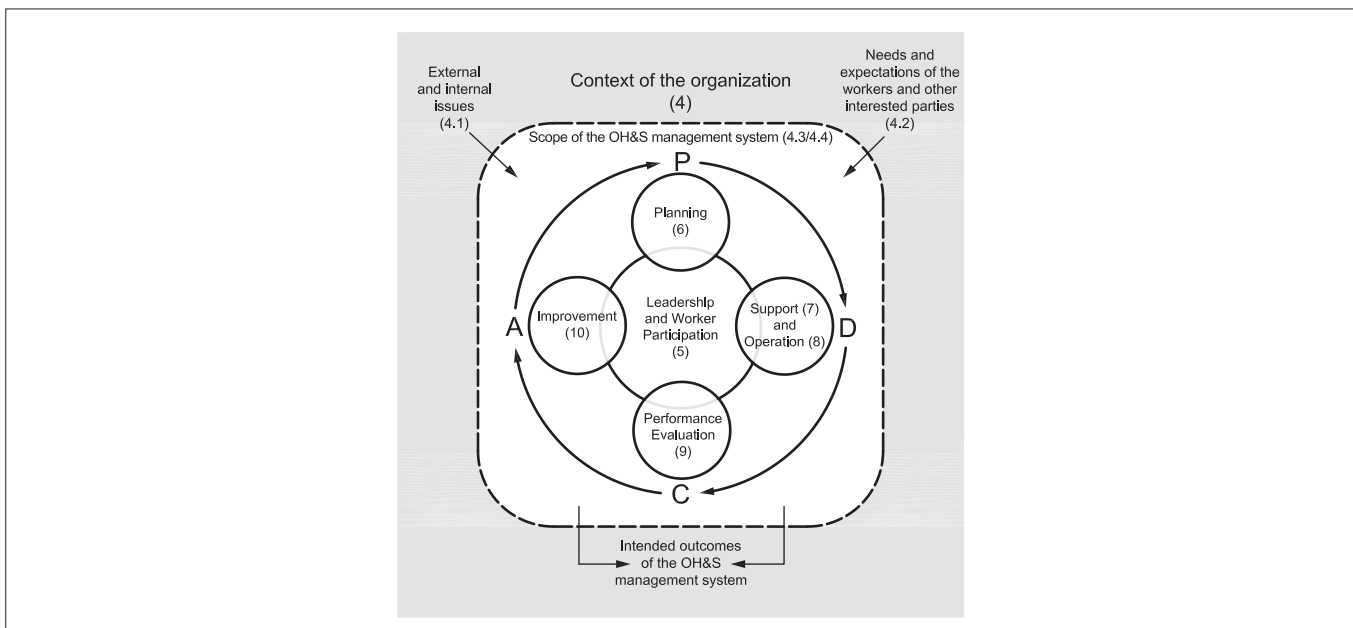
4.4 OH&S management system

The OH&S management system should reflect the context of the organization, e.g. be proportionate to its size and/or complexity and be properly resourced.

The OH&S management system should be aligned and integrated with other business processes and objectives to ensure that OH&S performance is not compromised to ensure that other objectives can be met, e.g. delivery objectives should not mean working so fast that it leads to safety short-cuts.

The organization should apply a PDCA approach towards its OH&S management system, as illustrated in [Figure 1](#).

- a) Plan – decide what the organization wants to achieve (taking into account the needs of interested parties, risks and opportunities), and put in place the necessary processes and resources.
- b) Do – put the plans into action.
- c) Check – monitor and measure processes and performance against requirements and what you want to achieve.
- d) Act – take actions on lessons learned and to improve performance.

Figure 1 — The PDCA cycle

NOTE Further guidance on PDCA in relation to OH&S is provided by the HSE (<http://www.hse.gov.uk/managing/plan-do-check-act.htm>).

5 Leadership and worker participation

COMMENTARY ON CLAUSE 5

This clause provides guidance on how to demonstrate leadership related to the OH&S management system and ensure adequate worker participation in its development, implementation and improvement.

This includes developing an OH&S policy, outlining roles, responsibilities and authorities for the OH&S management system, and the processes necessary for consultation and participation of workers.

5.1 Leadership and commitment

Leadership, commitment and active support from top management are critical for the success of the OH&S management system and achieving its intended outcomes. If workers see that top management takes OH&S performance seriously, this cascades down through the organization and helps establish a positive OH&S culture.

Leadership and commitment can be shown by, for example:

- aligning the OH&S management system with the organization's business objectives;
- making sure the necessary resources are available;
- encouraging workers and other relevant interested parties to get actively involved in improving OH&S performance;
- involving everyone in OH&S decision-making that affects them;
- promoting open discussion about OH&S matters; and
- ensuring the emphasis is on improvement rather than blame.

The organization can improve OH&S culture by, for example:

- providing clear and consistent leadership;
- promoting formal and informal involvement of workers;

- 3) making sure rules or processes are practical and proportionate to the risks;
- 4) responding to serious incidents by applying appropriate rules and safeguards rather than imposing measures across all activities regardless of need; and
- 5) considering long-term, delayed and hidden impacts, e.g. extended time between exposure to a hazard and ill health.

5.2 OH&S policy

OH&S policy is a set of commitments to achieve positive OH&S outcomes.

The responsibility for establishing, implementing and maintaining an OH&S policy rests with the organization's top management.

To meet the requirements of ISO 45001 the OH&S policy should be available as documented information (see [7.5](#)).

Commonly accepted practice is a one-page statement of key principles, however, the policy could also be presented as a poster, a web page or anything else which meets the organization's needs and complies with legal or other requirements.

NOTE Under UK legislation, there is no requirement for businesses employing less than five people to create a "written" policy; however, workers need to be able to state what the policy is.

In developing its OH&S policy, an organization should ensure the agreed commitments align with other policies in the organization and that workers understand the overall commitment of the organization to OH&S.

The policy should take account of:

- a) the current OH&S situation and what the organization wants to achieve;
- b) broader business objectives; and
- c) opportunities for improving the health and safety of workers.

The policy should be reviewed periodically to ensure that it remains relevant and appropriate to the organization. It is up to the organization how often this review is done.

If changes are made, the revised policy should be communicated, as appropriate.

5.3 Organizational roles, responsibilities and authorities

Top management is responsible for the OH&S management system, even if day-to-day decisions and work are delegated to others. What is delegated and to whom should be clear and communicated effectively so that anyone affected understands who is responsible for what.

5.4 Consultation and participation of workers

Involvement of workers in the OH&S management system and the processes that support it is a key requirement of effective OH&S management as it enables the organization to make informed decisions and increases worker engagement.

Workers involved in day-to-day activities and those closest to the risk can provide insight into potential problems. Decisions made jointly with these workers are more likely to be effective. The organization does not need to involve every worker in every decision, however, or act on every suggestion. Consultation and participation should be both effective and proportionate, e.g. purchase of a new first aid kit does not need consultation or participation of all workers.

It is up to the organization to determine the best way(s) of ensuring effective consultation and participation and whether it needs to set up formal mechanisms such as health and safety committees. Once mechanisms have been determined, it is important that they are given full top

management support. Consultation is about seeking workers' views, and considering them, before making a decision; participation is about joint decision-making, e.g. jointly assessing risks and agreeing actions, or deciding the organization's OHS policy and objectives.

A small organization can include all workers in discussions and decision-making. For larger organizations, it can be more effective to consult with one or more workers' representatives than attempt to consult with large numbers of workers directly. Other mechanisms for consultation and participation include, for example, focused team meetings, workshops, worker surveys and suggestion schemes.

The organization should take into account the specific issue(s) being considered when choosing the best way to find out workers' views and how much time and resource should be devoted to consultation and participation on a particular topic. Relevant non-managerial workers affected by the issue should be involved in deciding what the best mechanism is to ensure their concerns are addressed and to encourage engagement.

The organization should ensure that processes for consultation and participation of workers include contractors and other relevant people, e.g. volunteers or people working in parts of the organization not covered by the management system but carrying out work under the organization's control. This can include, for example, consultation with contractors on issues such as dealing with hazards which might be new or unfamiliar to them.

6 Planning

COMMENTARY ON CLAUSE 6

This clause provides guidance on how to plan for the OH&S management system, including identifying and assessing the risks and opportunities associated with it and the actions necessary to deal with these risks and opportunities.

This includes hazard identification, determining legal requirements and other requirements, i.e. other commitments the organization has made, and setting objectives for improvement.

6.1 Actions to address risks and opportunities

6.1.1 General

The overall purpose of planning for the OH&S management system is:

- a) to determine the risks that can affect OH&S performance and the management system;
- b) to manage these risks; and
- c) to determine where there are opportunities to improve OH&S performance and the OH&S management system.

Planning should be proportionate to the level of risk identified and the objectives of the organization as a whole, taking into account the context of the organization, including the needs and expectations of relevant interested parties (see [Clause 4](#)).

Whilst the organization should consider all potential risks to OH&S performance, it is not necessary to keep detailed documented information for all of them. The focus should be on those hazards which are most likely to occur and/or have the most impact and lead to the most significant risks.

For opportunities, focus should be on those that can realistically be acted upon, with priority given to those that can most improve performance.

6.1.2 Hazard identification and assessment of risks and opportunities

6.1.2.1 Hazard identification

Hazard identification helps the organization recognize and understand hazards in the workplace in order to plan how to eliminate them and reduce risks. The process should identify work-related sources, situations or circumstances with the potential to cause injury or ill-health.

Hazard identification should be an on-going process, not a singular or timed event. It should take into account normal activities, day-to-day fluctuations (e.g. variations caused by holidays, illness or staff changes) and planned changes, such as a major refurbishment. The process should look at both physical aspects, including facilities, equipment, materials, substances, and the working environment (light, noise, temperature) and human factors, including the potential for human error.

Ways of identifying hazards can vary, e.g. an organization can begin by looking around the workplace, looking at manufacturers' instructions, reviewing past accidents/incidents and by consulting workers.

Hazards can be categorized in many ways, for example:

- a) physical (e.g. working at height),
- b) chemical, biological (e.g. viruses, bacteria, harmful plants);
- c) psychosocial (e.g. stress, bullying, harassment);
- d) physiological (e.g. extreme temperatures); and
- e) mechanical and/or electrical.

Checklists can be used as a reminder of the types of potential hazards, however, such checklists are never exhaustive.

NOTE Further guidance on hazard identification is provided by the HSE (<http://www.hse.gov.uk/risk/identify-the-hazards.htm>).

6.1.2.2 Assessment of OH&S risks and other risks to the OH&S management system

Each organization should choose an appropriate way to assess risks, taking into account its own situation and activities. Whatever methods are chosen, they should be appropriate in balancing levels of risk with detail, complexity, time, cost and availability of reliable data.

Workers involved in the day-to-day activities should participate in the assessment of risks so that a full understanding is gained.

Some organizations develop generic risk assessments for typical activities taking place in different sites or locations. These can be a useful starting point for developing customized assessments for a particular situation. This approach can also help make the process more efficient and improve consistency of assessments for similar tasks. Care should be taken, however, to ensure that generic assessments fully consider the differing contexts of sites or situations.

The organization should consider the consequences of both short-term and long-term exposure to hazards and how risks can be increased by other factors, e.g. exposure to fumes in a well-ventilated space can present a much lower risk than the same exposure in a confined space, but the level of risk can be increased by additional factors such as extreme temperature or prolonged exposure.

NOTE 1 For further information, see the HSE guidance on control of substances hazardous to health (<http://www.hse.gov.uk/coshh/index.htm>).

The organization should consider the appropriate methodology and criteria for assessing risks associated with different types of hazards, e.g. methods for assessing stress differ from those related to exposure to chemicals.

If an assessment method uses descriptions for assessing severity or likelihood of harm, they should be clearly defined, e.g. clear definitions of terms such as likely/unlikely, minor/major/catastrophic are needed to ensure that people interpret them in the same way.

Particular attention should be given to the risks to sensitive (e.g. pregnant workers) and vulnerable groups (e.g. young workers, inexperienced workers).

NOTE 2 For further information, see the HSE guidance (<http://www.hse.gov.uk/vulnerable-workers/>).

The organization should also consider risks which are not directly related to the health and safety of people but which affect the OH&S management system itself and can have an impact on its intended outcomes.

Risks to the OH&S management system include:

- a) failure to address the needs and expectations of relevant interested parties;
- b) inadequate planning or allocation of resources;
- c) an ineffective audit programme;
- d) poor succession planning for key roles; and
- e) poor engagement by top management.

6.1.2.3 Assessment of OH&S opportunities and other opportunities to the OH&S management system

Opportunities to improve OH&S performance can include:

- a) considering hazards and risks when planning and designing a new facility, buying equipment or introducing a new process and other planned changes;
- b) alleviating monotonous work or work at a pre-determined work rate by ensuring workers are rotated to other activities; and
- c) using technology to improve OH&S performance, e.g. automating high-risk activities.

Opportunities to improve the OH&S management system can include:

- 1) making top management's support for the OH&S management system more visible, e.g. through communications such as social media or highlighting OH&S performance in strategic business plans;
- 2) improving the organizational culture related to safety and training;
- 3) enhancing incident investigation processes;
- 4) increasing worker participation in OH&S decision-making; and
- 5) collaborating with other organizations in forums which focus on OH&S.

6.1.3 Determination of legal requirements and other requirements

An organization's legal requirements and other requirements depend on its context (see [Clause 4](#)) and the requirements can change over time. They include requirements based on hazards and OH&S risks related to the organization's activities (see [6.1.2](#)) and can include:

- a) legal requirements, such as:
 - 1) regulations and supporting HSE codes of practice;
 - 2) orders issued by regulators, e.g. an improvement or prohibition notice by the HSE or local authority inspector;
 - 3) permits, licences or other forms of authorization; and

- b) other requirements such as:
 - 1) requirements of parent or partner organizations, customers and insurers;
 - 2) collective bargaining agreements;
 - 3) voluntary adherence to sector or trade body guidance;
 - 4) agreements with workers and other interested parties;
 - 5) conformity to voluntary standards, codes of practice, technical specifications, charters, etc; and
 - 6) public commitments of the organization or its parent organization.

To fulfil all requirements, the organization should ensure that legal requirements and other requirements can be identified, evaluated for applicability, accessed, communicated and kept up to date, e.g. by visiting regulatory websites and receiving notifications of new laws, or by receiving updates from trade associations.

Legal requirements and other requirements relevant to an organization are applicable to its:

- 1) activities;
- 2) processes;
- 3) equipment;
- 4) materials;
- 5) workers; and
- 6) location(s), including specific facilities.

The organization should ensure that relevant workers know how to access information on applicable legal requirements and other requirements. It isn't necessary to keep copies of the requirements; knowing how to access them and being able to do so when needed is enough.

NOTE For guidance on legal requirements, see the HSE website (<http://www.hse.gov.uk/managing/legal.htm>). Trade bodies and other organizations can also provide guidance.

6.1.4 Planning action

The organization should ensure specific plans are in place for the elimination of hazards and reduction of OH&S risks, either through the OH&S management system or through other business systems, e.g. business continuity, financial or human resource management, or a combination of processes.

When a need to control hazards is identified, the planning activity should determine how the controls are implemented (see [Clause 8](#)). Controls can sometimes take the form of measuring or monitoring (see [Clause 9](#)). The effectiveness of the actions taken to control hazards can be measured through the OH&S management system or through other management systems.

6.2 OH&S objectives and planning to achieve them

6.2.1 OH&S objectives

The organization should establish objectives in order to maintain and improve the OH&S management system and to achieve continual improvement in OH&S performance.

Objectives should be linked to the OH&S risks, opportunities and performance criteria which the organization has identified as having the highest priority. These should be proportionate to the scale, complexity and nature of the organization, e.g. for a small and/or low risk organization one or two simple objectives could be sufficient.

Once a level of performance has been achieved and no further improvement is practicable, an objective can be set to maintain that level of performance until new opportunities are identified.

Types of objectives can include those to:

- a) achieve a numerical value (e.g. reduce manual handling incidents by 20%, increase OH&S training by 20%);
- b) eliminate hazards or introduce controls (e.g. noise reduction);
- c) introduce less hazardous materials in specific products;
- d) increase worker satisfaction in relation to OH&S (e.g. by acting on worker suggestions);
- e) increase awareness of, or competence in, performing work tasks safely; and
- f) meet legal requirements before they come into force.

OH&S objectives can be broken down into tasks, depending on the size of the organization, complexity of the objective and the intended timescale.

6.2.2 Planning to achieve OH&S objectives

When planning to achieve its OH&S objectives, the organization should determine:

- a) what is to be done and by when;
- b) the resources needed;
- c) who is responsible; and
- d) how the results are to be evaluated.

The organization should decide how OH&S objectives are documented and how it plans to achieve them, e.g. it can develop formal project plans for complex objectives with multiple tasks or choose to create a simple flow chart or bullet point list for simple objectives.

NOTE It can sometimes be useful to keep information on the background and reasons for particular objectives, to help with future review, but this is not a requirement.

7 Support

COMMENTARY ON CLAUSE 7

This clause provides guidance on the support needed to ensure the OH&S management system can function effectively, including the resources, competence, communication, awareness and requirements for documented information.

7.1 Resources

The organization should decide on the resources needed to achieve OH&S objectives, e.g. money, people, equipment, organizational knowledge, and any constraints, e.g. budget, schedules, that should be taken into account.

7.2 Competence

To improve OH&S performance, it is important that both the organization and individual workers understand what it means to be “competent” and how this can be achieved and demonstrated. Competence includes being able to spot hazards and assess risks as well as having the ability to perform activities in a way that protects the health and safety of workers.

The organization should ensure competence requirements are established, and that workers have the relevant competence to carry out their activities in a safe and healthy way. The competence

of workers typically comprises a mixture of education, training, skills, and experience and can be demonstrated in different ways, including formal qualifications.

As well as a general understanding of competence requirements, the organization and its workers should identify tasks that require a specific level of competence before they can be carried out, e.g. welding or non-destructive testing. It might also be necessary for workers to be formally qualified for some tasks, e.g. forklift or truck driving.

When a worker does not meet, or no longer meets, competence requirements, action should be taken. Actions can include, but are not limited to:

- a) mentoring the worker;
- b) providing training and/or supervision;
- c) simplifying the work or activity so that competence requirements are reduced without compromising OH&S performance; and/or
- d) re-assigning work to someone with the necessary competence.

The organization should evaluate the effectiveness of actions taken to increase competence. For example, the organization can ask workers who have received training whether they consider themselves to have achieved the necessary competence to do their work or assess the worker's competence through role play, peer review or supervision.

When work is carried out by an external provider, the organization can put in place additional controls such as specifying competence requirements in contracts or service level agreements, or performing audits of the outsourced activities or functions. The organization is responsible for determining the action to be taken and this can vary, depending on how critical the competence is in ensuring OH&S objectives are met.

The organization should retain appropriate documented information that provides evidence of a worker's competence, e.g. existing HR and other information such as CVs or training logs.

7.3 Awareness

Every worker should be made aware of the OH&S management system, what it is trying to achieve, how it affects them and how their own actions can affect it. This is achieved when workers fully understand their own responsibilities and authority to act, and how their actions contribute to the achievement of OH&S objectives and the effectiveness of the OH&S management system.

Workers should also be made aware of relevant hazards and related OH&S risks that can impact them, including those that might not be related to their individual activities, e.g. hazards arising from other activities taking place nearby. Any investigations into incidents that relate to these hazards or risks, or a potential situation that could affect workers, should also be communicated, along with any corrective actions taken to prevent repeat incidents. Appropriate communication (see [7.4](#)) is key to achieving the necessary level of awareness.

7.4 Communication

7.4.1 General

It is up to the organization to decide how it communicates information about the OH&S management system to workers. Communications should be suitable for the audience, taking into account diversity such as gender, language, culture, literacy and disability.

The communications needs of shift workers, remote workers and part-time workers should be met, as appropriate.

It is also important to consider the complexity of the organization to ensure that messages are communicated effectively across different levels and functions, e.g. whilst in some situations a page on the intranet or an email might work, in others a one-to-one or team meeting, poster, video or handy wallet card might be more effective.

7.4.2 Internal communication

Communication within the organization should include information relating to:

- a) top management's commitment to the OH&S management system (e.g. programmes undertaken and resources committed to improving OH&S performance);
- b) how workers can raise concerns and/or make suggestions;
- c) the OH&S policy, including what it means at a practical level for workers;
- d) the identification of hazards and their related risks (e.g. information on process flows, materials in use, equipment specifications and observation of work practices) and opportunities that the organization intends to act on;
- e) OH&S objectives and actions being taken to improve performance;
- f) progress in eliminating OH&S hazards and risks (e.g. status reports showing the progress of projects that have been completed or are underway);
- g) changes that might impact the OH&S management system; and
- h) incident investigation (e.g. the type of incidents that are taking place, factors that can contribute to the occurrence of incidents, the outcomes of investigations and resulting actions).

7.4.3 External communication

Communication with people outside the organization can differ from internal communication. The extent of the communication should be related to the OH&S risks faced by external interested parties such as contractors and other visitors, as well as the local community and emergency services, and take into account any relevant legal requirements and other requirements, e.g. statutory incident reporting.

It is important to develop and maintain arrangements for communicating with contractors and other visitors to the workplace. This can be done in different ways, depending on what needs to be communicated and who it needs to be communicated to.

Contracts are often used to communicate OH&S performance requirements to external providers such as contractors, but the organization should also use methods such as on-site induction to raise awareness to individual workers of relevant hazards and risks, local rules and precautions, or actions to be taken in case of emergency.

In addition to communicating performance requirements, the organization should communicate the consequences associated with nonconformity with OH&S requirements, e.g. the impact of an accident or incident or the possibility of cancelling a contract due to poor OH&S performance.

If anything changes in relation to OH&S over the course of a period of work, this should be communicated to external providers as soon as possible.

In addition to communication about specific OH&S requirements for activities being carried out, the following should also be taken into account when communicating with external providers:

- a) the need to align external interested parties' OH&S policies and processes with those of the organization and other contractors at the worksite;
- b) previous OH&S performance, trends and incidents;

- c) the use of multiple contractors at the worksite;
- d) emergency arrangements;
- e) the need for additional consultation and/or provision for high-risk tasks;
- f) processes for incident investigation, reporting problems and taking corrective action; and
- g) arrangements for day-to-day communications.

Tools such as warning signs, posters, videos or audio messages can be effective methods of communicating to occasional and infrequent visitors, to the workplace, e.g. delivery people, customers, members of the public.

When deciding what should be communicated to such visitors, the organization should consider issues such as:

- 1) specific OH&S processes and practices relevant to their visit, e.g. wearing a hard hat on a construction site, or hearing protection in a noisy environment;
- 2) emergency evacuation arrangements and if there are planned drills during the time of the visit;
- 3) traffic controls; and
- 4) accessibility.

The organization should ensure arrangements are in place for receiving, recording and responding to relevant communications from external interested parties and for providing relevant information in an accessible and timely way. Appointing designated contacts can be an effective way of ensuring communication is consistent. This can be especially important in emergency situations where regular updates are requested.

7.5 Documented information

7.5.1 General

Organizations should create and keep documented information relating to the OH&S management system and its processes to the extent that it is necessary for effectiveness.

NOTE 1 Attention is drawn to relevant legal requirements and other requirements.

An extensive paper trail and record-keeping do not by themselves promote good OH&S management. Documented information should be driven by what is needed for effective OH&S management, rather than for its own sake.

Documented information can be whatever suits the organization and the task at hand, e.g. electronic spreadsheets, notes on smart phones, photographs, traditional log books or work instructions, online instruction videos. For many organizations, a mix of different types of documented information works well.

When there is a requirement to maintain documented information, this means keep it up to date. A requirement to retain means that the information should be kept safely, unaltered, to provide a record. When working electronically, version controls and passwords can be effective ways of ensuring documented information is not changed without authorization.

In general, ISO 45001 is not prescriptive about the level of documented information required. This varies from organization to organization, e.g. documented information needed for a small local bakery is likely to be simpler and less extensive than that required by an international automotive parts manufacturer which has very specific customer (statutory and regulatory) requirements.

7.5.2 Creating and updating

Where it is necessary for the OH&S management system, documented information should be identified and described. This can mean giving something a title, e.g. “Site rules” on a poster, a reference number, e.g. “20180101 Management meeting minutes”, or anything else that helps uniquely identify it to make sure the correct piece of documented information can be found.

When creating documented information, the following should be considered:

- a) translating into other languages;
- b) software versions;
- c) whether it is compatible with smart phones or tablets; and
- d) accessibility for those with special needs, e.g. audio versions of text.

7.5.3 Control of documented information

Having decided on the documented information needed for the OH&S management system, the organization should ensure it is available for all relevant workers at all levels and functions as well as any relevant external, interested parties.

The same documented information can be presented in different formats for different users, however, controls should be put in place to ensure it is used as intended, e.g. data cannot be changed without permission and confidentiality is maintained on sensitive information.

8 Operation

COMMENTARY ON CLAUSE 8

This clause provides guidance on the operational planning and control necessary for the OH&S management system and includes eliminating hazards and reducing OH&S risks, managing change, emergency preparedness and response as well as guidance on procurement, contractors and outsourcing.

8.1 Operational planning and control

8.1.1 General

Processes should be established to enable the OH&S management system to achieve its intended outcomes and these processes should be controlled.

Examples of the processes needed include, but are not limited to those for:

- a) consultation and participation of workers;
- b) hazard identification and risk assessment;
- c) determination of, and compliance with, legal requirements and other requirements;
- d) communication;
- e) management of change;
- f) emergency preparedness and response; and
- g) monitoring, measurement, analysis and performance evaluation.

Controls and criteria relating to those processes can include, for example:

- 1) documentation and detailed systems of work;
- 2) specifications for the procurement of goods and services;

- 3) ensuring compliance with regulations and manufacturers' instructions;
- 4) checking and raising the competence of workers;
- 5) maintenance and inspection programmes, e.g. routine housekeeping;
- 6) health surveillance, work permits; and
- 7) adapting work to workers, e.g. reasonable adjustments for workers with specific needs, appropriate design of workplaces, etc.

When planning and developing operational controls, priority should be given to control options with higher reliability in preventing work-related injury and ill health.

The controls should take into account both existing processes and any new processes introduced to achieve the organization's objectives.

8.1.2 Eliminating hazards and reducing OH&S risks

OH&S risks are commonly managed using a system called the hierarchy of controls. The hierarchy of controls provides a structured guide to eliminating hazards and reducing or controlling OH&S risks. Each step is less effective than the one before, although several steps can often be combined to effectively reduce risks to a level that is as low as reasonably practicable.

When deciding what is reasonably practicable, best practices and technological options should be taken into account, together with financial, operational and business requirements.

The following examples illustrate control measures that can be implemented at each level:

- a) *hazard elimination*: removing the hazard completely, e.g. through workplace re-design or process change;
- b) *substitution*: if a hazard cannot be removed, replacing the dangerous by the non-dangerous, or the less dangerous; e.g. using water-based paint rather than solvent-based paint, or buying pre-cut building materials instead of cutting on-site;
- c) *engineering controls/work reorganization*: if a hazard cannot be removed completely or replaced with something less harmful, practical changes can be made to reduce the risk, e.g. machine guarding or local exhaust ventilation systems, providing physical separation of pedestrians and vehicles, alarms, changing working hours, reducing the effect of monotonous activities by rotating workers;
- d) *administrative controls/training*: e.g. safety signs, using standard operating instructions, emergency instructions, training in manual handling or to recognize the symptoms of stress; and
- e) *personal protective equipment (PPE)*: e.g. hard hats, safety shoes, hearing protection.

The control measures should be checked, as necessary, to make sure they work as well as intended and to see if any better ways of controlling the risks can be implemented. It is also important to regularly check that any equipment used as a control works properly, e.g. machinery guarding, interlocks, fire alarms, sprinklers, carbon monoxide monitors.

Administrative controls should also be evaluated, e.g. floor walking to check workers are following work instructions, consulting with workers to ensure no one is working excessive hours or skipping breaks.

8.1.3 Management of change

The organization should plan for change and ensure sufficient resources are available to make sure that changes do not introduce new and unforeseen hazards (see [6.1.4](#)) or increase the OH&S risks. Planned changes also give organizations the chance to implement opportunities for improvements (see [6.1.2](#)).

8.1.4 Procurement

8.1.4.1 General

Procurement processes should be used to control potential hazards and reduce OH&S risks associated with something being introduced into the workplace, e.g. products, raw materials, substances, new equipment, services, etc.

Before use, the organization should check that what has been procured is suitable and any related hazards or OH&S risks are at an acceptable level.

For example, the organization can put in place a process to check that:

- a) equipment is delivered according to specification and tested to ensure it works as intended;
- b) installations function as designed;
- c) materials are delivered according to their specifications; and
- d) usage requirements, precautions or other protective measures are available and communicated to workers and others who could be affected.

8.1.4.2 Contractors

The organization should delegate authority to those best capable of identifying, evaluating and controlling OH&S risks, including, where necessary, contractors with specialized knowledge, skills, methods and means. Organizations should note, however, that this delegation does not eliminate the organization's responsibility for the health and safety of its workers.

Contracts that clearly define the responsibilities of everyone involved can help organizations to manage contractors' activities effectively. Contract award mechanisms or pre-qualification criteria which take account of past OH&S performance, safety training, or health and safety capabilities, as well as direct contract requirements, can be helpful.

How an organization manages often diverse and complex relationships with contractors can vary, depending on the nature and extent of the services provided and the associated hazards and risks. When deciding how to coordinate, the organization should consider factors such as:

- a) reporting of hazards between itself and its contractors;
- b) controlling worker access to hazardous areas and activities;
- c) reporting contractor or interested party injuries and/or ill-health; and
- d) processes to follow in emergencies.

8.1.4.3 Outsourcing

When an organization outsources activities, e.g. billing, printing, internal auditing, welding, galvanizing, chrome plating, spray painting, rather than carrying them out internally, it still retains responsibility for OH&S risks and ensuring appropriate controls are in place.

An outsourced function or process is one that:

- a) is integral to the organization's functioning;
- b) is within the scope of the OH&S management system; and
- c) is perceived by interested parties as being carried out by the organization itself.

The type and degree of control to be applied to outsourced functions and processes should be defined within the OH&S management system and the organization should put in place appropriate controls both to make sure that the external provider understands what is needed and to assure the organization that this is being carried out in an acceptable way.

Controls can include such things as contractual requirements, training, inspections and risk assessments.

8.2 Emergency preparedness and response

The organization should identify potential emergency situations and plan its response in proportion to the risk. The organization should focus on proactive control measures (e.g. the elimination of ignition sources), as well as reactive risk controls (e.g. fire-fighting equipment and evacuation).

In planning its emergency response, the organization should take account of the needs of relevant interested parties, e.g. workers, visitors, emergency services and neighbours. The identified emergency situations should be subject to regular review, taking into account the potential impact of any changes to processes or systems of work (see [8.1.3](#)).

When planning, the organization should take into account previous similar emergencies and the findings of any associated investigation as well as general considerations of its own situation, including:

- a) numbers and locations of workers and other people who could be affected;
- b) availability of local emergency services and details of any emergency response arrangements in place; and
- c) competence of workers and needs of vulnerable people.

Emergency plans should be made available to all workers, visitors and contractors, including individual copies for workers with specific roles and responsibilities. Organizations should ensure the plans are kept in accessible locations and in different media, e.g. physical copies such as posters or printed instructions in case of power failure, as well as electronic copies that can be accessed remotely.

The emergency plans should describe the roles, responsibilities and authorities of those with specified duties, identified by job role, rather than by name.

Guidance should be given as to what is considered an emergency, who has the authority to declare an emergency, how it is to be communicated to workers and other relevant interested parties, including the emergency services.

Instructions should contain actions to be taken in an emergency by those affected, including how to raise the alarm and call for help, evacuation procedures, and locations of safe places, utility isolation points, emergency equipment, up-to-date site plans and who has an emergency role.

Every worker with specific roles and responsibilities for emergency response should be competent to fulfil them. A number of workers can be trained to undertake the role of emergency controller with the objective that, in the event of an emergency, one worker takes the team leader role supported by the other trained workers.

A control centre should be placed in a location unlikely to be affected by a major emergency, e.g. a large fire, explosion or release of a hazardous substance.

If the level of risk identified is significant it can be helpful to structure the response team on three levels; the top level dealing with strategic control, the second dealing with operational control and the third with control matters at the location of the emergency.

Emergency response equipment and supplies should be located in secure and easily accessible places, protected from damage. The equipment should be subject to regular testing to ensure that it is working. People who are designated to use the emergency equipment should have regular refresher training.

Periodic testing of emergency plans is needed to ensure that the organization, its workers and, where necessary, the emergency services can appropriately respond to the emergency situation. For a small, low risk organization, this might simply be a periodic fire evacuation drill.

It is essential that those with specific roles and responsibilities are fully involved in testing, the results of which can be used to identify, and therefore correct, any deficiencies.

The results of the testing and any corrective actions should be kept as documented information. This information should be reviewed with the test planners and participants to share feedback and recommendations for further improvement.

NOTE For further guidance on managing emergencies, see the HSE guidance, *Emergency procedures* (<http://www.hse.gov.uk/toolbox/managing/emergency.htm>).

9 Performance evaluation

COMMENTARY ON CLAUSE 9

This clause provides guidance on evaluating the performance of the OH&S management system. Guidance is given regarding what needs to be monitored, measured and analysed, including legal requirements and other requirements, together with arrangements for internal audits and management review.

9.1 Monitoring, measurement, analysis and performance evaluation

9.1.1 General

Organizations are not required to monitor or measure everything. The processes that are put in place should be useful, appropriate for what is being evaluated and proportionate to the level of risk involved, e.g. routinely checking that machine guards are in place and effective in protecting workers from harm is important, whilst annual electrical testing of a desk fan usually is not, and can be substituted by a visual check.

9.1.2 Evaluation of compliance

Exactly what the organization has to comply with is determined by its context and the scope of the OH&S management system (see [Clause 4](#) and [Clause 6](#)).

The organization should prioritize actions based upon the identified levels of compliance and any identified areas of nonconformance, specifically, where the organization is not complying with legal requirements and other requirements.

NOTE Legal compliance is the minimum standard in determining the effectiveness of the OH&S management system.

9.2 Internal audit

9.2.1 General

Internal audits are an effective way of checking how the organization is performing.

They should be carried out to provide information on the performance and effectiveness of the OH&S management system, to ensure that planned arrangements have been implemented and that the OH&S management system is effectively maintained.

9.2.2 Internal audit programme

Internal audits should be relevant to what materially affects the organization's OH&S performance and how the OH&S objectives are achieved, e.g. audits can include reviews of accident and incident

logs, subsequent investigations, and that planned corrective actions have been taken and are working as intended.

Audits should be planned and carried out by people who understand what they are auditing.

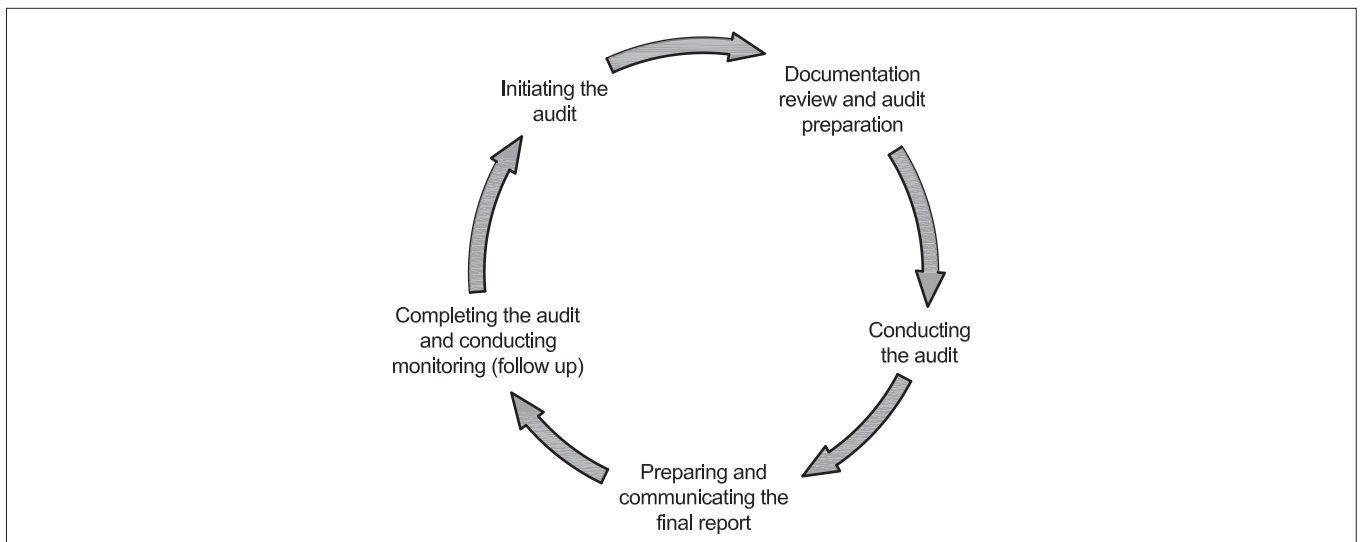
NOTE See [Figure 2](#) for a typical audit process.

How an audit is carried out, how often and who by depends on the size and complexity of the organization and its activities. Workers do not need to be professional auditors or have a formal auditing qualification; however, they should meet the competence requirements set out by the organization and be given appropriate guidance and training if necessary.

Ideally, audits should be conducted by workers who are not directly involved in the processes or activities being audited to ensure that they are carried out as objectively as possible and the results are unbiased. In small organizations this is not always possible and it is acceptable for someone to audit their own work, although every effort should be made to remove bias and encourage objectivity. Audits are more effective in an organization that has a positive OH&S culture and the objectives of the audit are to identify areas for improvement rather than attribute blame for nonconformities.

The organization should ensure that all elements of the audit, (e.g. planning schedule, scope and criteria, names of auditors, results, nonconformities and corrective actions taken or other outcomes such as improvement plans) are kept as documented information. This can be in a format suitable to the organization, whether this is formal audit plans and reports or less traditional formats, such as data stored spreadsheets or in emails. It is important that all of the information is available to relevant parties.

Figure 2 — Typical audit process



9.3 Management review

Management review is critical to ensure continual improvement of the OH&S management system. The purpose of these reviews is for top management to undertake a strategic and critical evaluation of the performance of the OH&S management to ensure it continues to be:

- a) suitable – does it still fit the organization, its operations and culture?
- b) adequate – is it still appropriate and sufficient?
- c) effective – does it achieve the intended outcomes?

The review should include all the listed topics given in ISO 45001:2018, **9.3** a) to g); however, they need not necessarily be addressed at the same time. The organization should determine when and how the topics are to be addressed.

The management review should draw a conclusion as to the continuing suitability and effectiveness of the OH&S management system and include any necessary decisions related to:

- 1) any need for changes to the OH&S management system;
- 2) continual improvement opportunities;
- 3) resource needs;
- 4) other actions needed, including to improve integration with other business processes; and
- 5) implications for the strategic direction of the organization.

Relevant outputs of the management review should be communicated to workers and, when applicable, their representatives (see [7.4.1](#)).

The organization should retain documented information as evidence of management review.

10 Improvement

COMMENTARY ON CLAUSE 10

This clause provides guidance on making improvements to the OH&S management system, including guidance on how to handle incidents, nonconformities, taking corrective actions and achieving continual improvement in the long term.

10.1 General

The organization should identify opportunities for improvement and implement the necessary actions in order to achieve the intended outcomes of the OH&S management system.

10.2 Incident, nonconformity and corrective action

Organizations should have processes in place for reporting and investigating incidents and other nonconformities, and for taking action to correct them and deal with their consequences.

Incidents, including near-misses, should be investigated so that under-reporting, recurrence or escalation into more serious incidents can be prevented.

When an OH&S issue is raised by a worker, or indicated by monitoring, sickness absence trends, or medical reports, the situation should be treated as an incident and investigated accordingly.

Examples of incidents and nonconformities include, but are not limited to:

- a) incidents: work-related near-miss events, injuries and ill health, exposures to health hazards, occupational diseases, property and equipment damage that can lead to OH&S risks, traffic accidents; and
- b) nonconformities: protective equipment not functioning properly, failure to apply legal requirements, prescribed procedures not being followed.

The aim of an incident investigation is to determine what happened, why it happened, and what can be done to prevent it from happening again. This means not only considering the immediate causes, but also the underlying or root causes and taking corrective actions to address these causes. When determining cause(s), the organization should ensure the analysis is focused on prevention and not on blame or punishment.

Almost all incidents have multiple causes. These can be related to a range of factors, including human behaviour, types of tasks and processes, equipment, competency or management of the organization. The investigation should identify all areas that need improvement, including improvements to the OH&S management system and propose suitable corrective actions.

Examples of corrective actions include, but are not limited to:

- a) moving up the hierarchy of controls (see [8.1.2](#));
- b) re-design, modification or replacement of equipment or tools;
- c) improving processes or implementing specific procedures;
- d) improving the competence of workers and/or the way work is organized; and
- e) changes in and use of personal protective equipment.

The level of investigation should be proportionate to the potential health and safety consequences of the incident. The incident should be reported and recorded internally and, where appropriate, reported externally to relevant authorities.

NOTE For further guidance on how to make a Reporting of Injuries, Diseases and Dangerous Occurrences Regulations (RIDDOR) report, see the HSE guidance (<http://www.hse.gov.uk/riddor/report.htm>).

It is good practice for minor incidents/near misses to be reported internally and investigated, to prevent reoccurrence or similar incidents becoming more serious. Investigating and acting on such incidents in a timely and transparent way can help build a culture of trust and cooperation between workers at different levels.

Where practicable, the investigation should be led by someone independent of the activities being investigated, and should include a worker or worker representative.

Recommendations should be communicated to all who might benefit from the lessons. It is good practice to implement recommendations as quickly as possible, as a visible sign that management are concerned about OH&S. Top management should always review investigation reports of significant incidents and nonconformities.

10.3 Continual improvement

Continual improvement in the suitability, adequacy and effectiveness of the OH&S management system needs to be demonstrated. Such improvement should be focused on enhancing OH&S performance and the culture that supports the OH&S management system.

Continual improvement can be achieved by a step-by-step approach to improve the OH&S management system and OH&S performance over time as well by innovation.

Examples include:

- a) the introduction and implementation of accepted good practice and benchmarking to improve processes and reduce risks;
- b) implementing suggestions and recommendations from workers and other interested parties; and
- c) applying new technology, materials, etc.

Bibliography

Standards publications

For dated references, only the edition cited applies. For undated references, the latest edition of the referenced document (including any amendments) applies.

ISO 45001:2018, *Occupational health and safety management systems — Requirements with guidance for use*

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